shows a "preferential love" for the poor and persecuted, who have to live the idea of Christian love in terms of resistance to oppression and evil.[12]

Liberation theologies combine Gramscian and neo-Marxist theories of power and authority as social institutions inherenely oppressive to the powerless, with the image of Jesus as the victim of a militaristic (Roman) Empire and the powerful Jewish clerical establishment which opposed him.[13] The Arab-Israeli conflict was not central to the work of liberationist theologians, but they have elaborated contextualized interpretations of Scripture, which shape political and social practce.[14] Thus, for instance, the Exodus is important to liberation theologies in order to describe the spiritual journey of the enslaved toward freedom, whereby each repressive regime is associated with the cursed Egyptian Pharaoh, and the impoverished masses with the enslaved Hebrews.[15] Appropriate theological interpretations of "martyrdom" and "love" are added to encourage the popular struggle for liberation.

This particular element is crucial to understanding Palestinian theology, in that it couples the concept of testimony with that of love to elaborate a political theology that supports "resistance" and the "fight" against oppression. This is done in an exclusively Christian fashion that officially rejects violence, but nonetheless justifies the resort to force when it is aimed at securing justice.[16] In this sense, many liberationist theologians expand on the concept of "preferential love for the poor" in order to present the oppressed as being free from sin, while their deeds are designed to call for the repentance of the powerful.[17]

The message of liberation theologies has been spread through the intense social activity of clergy, as well as through the resolute commitment of political activists that emerged in the 1970s and 1980s. As happened with the evolution of antisemitism, the Catholic Church has hesitantly endeavored to curb the revolutionary appeal of liberation theologies, specifically decrying the neo-Marxist connection, but the infusion of new hope and a religiously motivated reason to resist authoritarian regimes rapidly developed towards political action.[18]

In this respect, liberationist theologies have been further contextualized in diverse situations. The most remarkable development was in the South African liberation theology movement, which prospered around the Kairos South Africa Document of 1989. South African Christian churches under the spiritual guidance of Anglican Bishop Desmond Tutu, elaborated on the oppressor-oppressed tenet by interpreting the figure of Jesus as a paradigmatic victim of racist and nationalist political regimes.[19] In this context, the figure of Jesus as the liberator is portrayed not only as a rebel, but also as a radical reformer of any "nationalist" faith, stressing the superiority of a

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